Chapter 1 Support Vector Machine

Introduction

- *Constrained optimization*
- *Inequality optimization*
- *KKT condition*
- *Support Vector Machine*

Support Vector Machine (SVM) is also a binary classification model, often introduced as an alternative to logistic regression, since—as we have discussed in the previous chapter—logistic regression has several notable limitations. SVM provides an elegant framework that allows us to transfer powerful results and intuition from optimization theory into machine learning.

1.1 Constrained Optimization

Unlike the unconstrained optimization problems we studied earlier, the support vector machine is originally formulated as a **constrained optimization problem**. This distinction is fundamental. In mathematics, unconstrained optimization is defined as:

$$\underset{x}{\operatorname{argmin}}\, f(x) \tag{1.1}$$

When we deal with constrained optimization, we add an auxiliary constraint $h(x) = 0$ (where both $f(x)$ and $h(x)$ are differentiable). Considering the geometric meaning of the gradient, we observe:

1. For any point on the surface defined by $h(x)$, the gradient $\nabla h(x)$ must be orthogonal to the surface.
2. For any critical point x^* that achieves a local minimum, the gradient $\nabla f(x^*)$ must also be orthogonal to the surface.

Note

The second property can be understood by analogy with electrostatics: near a conductor, the electric field must be orthogonal to the surface. Otherwise, there would be a component of the field (gradient) along the constrained sub-hypersurface, violating equilibrium.

Extending this analogy: in the electrostatic case, such a tangential component would induce currents along the conductor's surface. In the optimization setting, a tangential component corresponds to a gradient lying along the constraint manifold, implying that the objective function can still be further optimized without violating the constraint.

Moreover, the charge distribution problem in electrostatics can itself be interpreted as an energy minimization process: the charges rearrange to minimize the system's electrostatic energy. In this sense, the equilibrium state of charges on a conductor can be seen as an optimization problem, which strengthens the analogy with constrained optimization in mathematics.

Combining the two conditions above, we obtain the **necessary** condition for a local minimum point, as shown in Figure 1.1:

$$\exists \lambda \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \nabla f(x^*) + \lambda \nabla h(x^*) = 0 \tag{1.2}$$

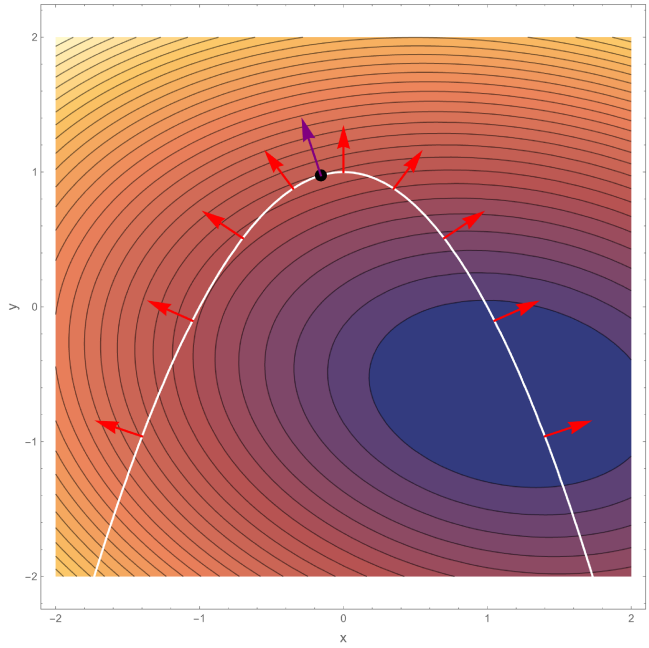


Figure 1.1: Illustration of the necessary condition for constrained local minima.

Remark

In some contour examples, the constraint condition does not cover the entire space. In such cases, the above equation may not *always be satisfied.*

Now we introduce the *Lagrangian function*, which plays a central role in optimization theory:

$$L(x, \lambda) := f(x) + \underbrace{\lambda}_{\text{Lagrange Multiplier}} h(x) \tag{1.3}$$

Extending to the case of multiple constraints, the Lagrangian is defined as:

$$L(x, \lambda) := f(x) + \sum_{i=1}^{k} \lambda_i h_i(x) \tag{1.4}$$

Theorem 1.1

If x^* is a local minimum point, then there exists a set of multipliers $\lambda = (\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_k)$ such that

$$\begin{cases} \nabla_x L(x^*, \lambda) = 0, \\ \nabla_\lambda L(x^*, \lambda) = 0. \end{cases} \tag{1.5}$$

The first condition corresponds to the stationarity (minimum) condition, while the second condition enforces the constraints.

Corollary 1.1

In multi-constrained problems, the minimum condition becomes

$$\nabla f(x^*) + \sum_{i=1}^{k} \lambda_i \nabla h_i(x^*) = 0. \tag{1.6}$$

Remark

In higher dimensions, the constrained submanifold may possess certain free variables that can be chosen arbitrarily while still satisfying the minimum condition. Specifically, if $\nabla f(x^*)$ cannot be expressed as a linear combination of $\nabla h_1(x^*)$ and $\nabla h_2(x^*)$, it is possible to continue optimizing along the intersection submanifold defined by $h_1 = 0$ and $h_2 = 0$, as shown in Figure 1.2. Therefore, it must be emphasized that the above equation provides only a ***necessary condition****, not a sufficient one.*

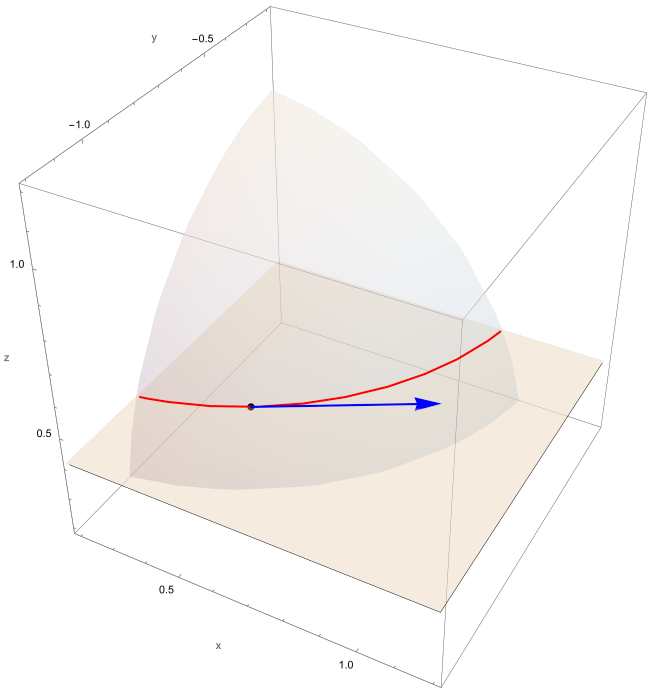


Figure 1.2: Illustration of optimization along the intersection of two constraint manifolds.

Example 1.1

Consider the following constrained optimization problem:

$$\underset{x_1, x_2}{\operatorname{argmin}} \; x_1 + x_2 \tag{1.7}$$

subject to the constraint

$$(x_1 - 1)^2 + x_2^2 - 1 = 0 \tag{1.8}$$

Solution

$1 - \sqrt{2}$.

Note

The Lagrange multiplier method can provide critical points, but these do not always correspond to the minimum solution.

Note

In convex settings, any local minimum is also a global minimum.

A new problem arises: what if we have an inequality constraint instead of a strict equality, i.e., $g(x) \leq 0$?

1.2 Inequality optimization

We assume the feasible set of x is compact; otherwise, the existence of a minimum may be problematic.

By gradient analysis, we obtain:

1. For any point on the surface $g(x) = 0$, $\nabla g(x)$ is orthogonal to the surface and points outward from the feasible region $g(x) \leq 0$. This is straightforward, since $\nabla g(x)$ indicates the steepest direction of increase.
2. For a local minimum point x^*:
   (a). If x^* lies on the surface $g(x) = 0$ (in other words, the constraint is *active*), then $-\nabla f(x^*)$ must be aligned with $\nabla g(x^*)$. Equivalently, $\exists\, \mu > 0$ such that
   $$\nabla f(x^*) + \mu \nabla g(x^*) = 0$$
   (b). If x^* does not lie on the surface, i.e., $g(x) < 0$ (the constraint is *inactive*), we simply require $\nabla f(x^*) = 0$. In the unified form above, this corresponds to $\exists\, \mu = 0$ such that
   $$\nabla f(x^*) + \mu \nabla g(x^*) = 0$$

Note

How should we understand the meaning of an "active" constraint? When the inequality constraint is not tight (i.e., $g(x) < 0$), it does not affect gradient descent optimization. In this case, the constraint is effectively absent, which is why we call it inactive.

Again, we define the Lagrangian as

$$L(x, \mu) = f(x) + \mu g(x) \tag{1.9}$$

where $g(x)$ denotes the inequality constraint function. Following the same steps as in the equality-constrained case, we obtain:

Theorem 1.2

If x^* is a local minimum point, then

$$\begin{cases} \nabla_x L(x^*, \mu) = 0, \\ g(x^*) \leq 0, \\ \mu \geq 0, \\ \mu \cdot g(x^*) = 0. \end{cases} \tag{1.10}$$

The last condition (the *complementary slackness*) unifies the boundary and interior cases, since either $g(x^*) = 0$ (active constraint) or $\mu = 0$ (inactive constraint) must hold.

1.3 General Case

In the most general case, we consider the optimization problem

$$\operatorname*{argmin}_x f(x) \tag{1.11}$$

subject to equality constraints $h_i(x) = 0,\ i \in [k]$, and inequality constraints $g_j(x) \leq 0,\ j \in [l]$.

The corresponding Lagrangian is defined as

$$L(x, \lambda, \mu) := f(x) + \sum_{i \in [k]} \lambda_i h_i(x) + \sum_{j \in [l]} \mu_j g_j(x) \tag{1.12}$$

In this setting, a local minimum x^* must satisfy a series of conditions known as the **Karush–Kuhn–Tucker (KKT) conditions**:

Theorem 1.3 (KKT Conditions)

If x^* is a local minimum point, then there exist multipliers (λ, μ) such that

$$\begin{cases} \nabla_x L(x^*, \lambda, \mu) = 0, & \\ h_i(x^*) = 0, & \forall i \in [k], \\ g_j(x^*) \leq 0, & \forall j \in [l], \\ \mu_j \geq 0, & \forall j \in [l], \\ \mu_j \cdot g_j(x^*) = 0, & \forall j \in [l]. \end{cases} \tag{1.13}$$

♡

In most cases, the above conditions cannot be solved explicitly in closed form.

1.4 Support Vector Machine

1.4.1 Hard Margin

Consider a linearly separable dataset $\{(x_i, y_i)\}$ with $y_i \in \{-1, 1\}$, and a linear model

$$f(x) = w^\top x + b \tag{1.14}$$

Although introducing a regularization term can make the solution unique by adjusting the hyperparameter λ, this does not resolve the issue of determining which solution $f(x; \lambda)$ is preferable among all possible choices, since λ is itself arbitrary.

Our goal is for the model to generalize well to test data drawn from the same distribution as the training set. A direct and intuitive way to achieve this is to choose the separating hyperplane that maximizes the distance between the plane and the nearest datapoints.

Definition 1.1 (Support Vectors)

The datapoints that lie closest to the separating hyperplane, such that the vectors orthogonal to the hyperplane connect the hyperplane to these datapoints, are called support vectors.

♣

In the case of SVM, we aim to find the **Max-Margin Classifier**, i.e., the hyperplane that maximizes the minimum margin across all training points. Here, the *margin* refers to the distance from a point to the hyperplane, which is equivalently the norm of the vector associated with its support vector.

Remark

Why does $w^\top x + b = 0$ represent a hyperplane? Consider the hyperplane through the origin, given by $w^\top x = 0$. Translating this plane until it passes through some point $x_0 \notin \{x \mid w^\top x = 0\}$, we obtain

$$w^\top (x - x_0) = 0$$

Setting $-w^\top x_0 = b$, we recover the general hyperplane equation

$$w^\top x + b = 0$$

Remark

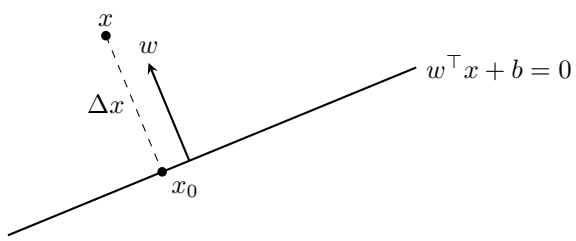
Note that the interpretation of b differs between the two cases, $y = w^\top x + b_f$ and $0 = w^\top x + b_e$. We denote b_f as the bias in the functional form and b_e as the bias in the implicit equation form to distinguish between the two. In the latter case, we observe that $|b_e| = \|w\|\|x_0\|$, which represents the offset determined by the reference point x_0.

The distance between a datapoint and the hyperplane is given by:

Theorem 1.4

$$d = \frac{|w^\top x + b|}{\|w\|}. \tag{1.15}$$

Geometrically, we obtain:



Proof

1. *Consider*

$$\begin{cases} x_0 + \Delta x \dfrac{w}{\|w\|} = x, \\ w^\top x_0 + b = 0, \end{cases}$$

so that

$$\begin{aligned} & w^\top x_0 + w^\top \Delta x \frac{w}{\|w\|} = w^\top x \\ \Rightarrow \quad & -b + w^\top \Delta x \frac{w}{\|w\|} = w^\top x \\ \Rightarrow \quad & \Delta x \|w\| = w^\top x + b \end{aligned}$$

This matches exactly the expression we obtained in (1.15).

2. *From the Lagrangian perspective:*

$$\underset{x_0}{\operatorname{argmin}} \frac{1}{2}\|x - x_0\|^2 \quad s.t.\ w^\top x_0 + b \quad \Rightarrow \quad L(x_0, \lambda) = \frac{1}{2}\|x - x_0\|^2 + \lambda(w^\top x_0 + b)$$

$$\Rightarrow \quad \begin{cases} \nabla_{x_0} L(x_0, \lambda) & = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad x_0 - x + \lambda w = 0 \\ \nabla_\lambda L(x_0, \lambda) & = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad w^\top x_0 + b = 0 \end{cases}$$

This leads to the same solution as above.

■

When $\Delta := (w^\top x + b)/\|w\| > 0$, the point x lies on the positive side of the hyperplane; when $\Delta = 0$, x lies exactly on the hyperplane; and when $\Delta < 0$, x lies on the negative side.

We define

$$\gamma_i = \frac{y_i(w^\top x_i + b)}{\|w\|} \tag{1.16}$$

to incorporate both the label information and the margin (distance to the hyperplane). If $\gamma_i > 0$, the point x_i is correctly

classified.

Define the margin

$$\gamma = \operatorname*{argmin}_{i \in [n]} \gamma_i \tag{1.17}$$

and the SVM optimization problem can be formalized as

$$\operatorname*{argmax}_{w,b} \ \gamma, \quad \text{s.t. } \forall i, \ \frac{y_i(w^\top x_i + b)}{\|w\|} \geq \gamma \tag{1.18}$$

This formulation is problematic, since γ is not an independent variable but is defined as the minimum of the γ_i's. To resolve this, suppose (x_0, y_0) is a point achieving the minimum margin γ. Then

$$\gamma = \frac{y_0(w^\top x_0 + b)}{\|w\|} \tag{1.19}$$

Thus, the SVM objective can be reformulated as

$$\operatorname*{argmax}_{w,b} \ \frac{y_0(w^\top x_0 + b)}{\|w\|}, \quad \text{s.t. } \forall i, \ y_i(w^\top x_i + b) \geq y_0(w^\top x_0 + b). \tag{1.20}$$

We claim that we can make $y_0(w^\top x_0 + b)$ arbitrarily large without affecting the result.

Remark

This is immediate: scaling w and b by the same factor λ does not change the optimization, since the numerator $y_i(w^\top x_i + b)$ and the denominator $\|w\|$ both scale by λ, and the factor cancels during simplification.

Thus, we may set $y_0(w^\top x_0 + b) = 1$. Define the *functional margin* as $y_i(w^\top x_i + b)$ and the *geometric margin* as $y_i(w^\top x_i + b)/\|w\|$. Since the functional margin alone has no intrinsic meaning, it is natural to rescale it by setting the norm of the support vector to unity.

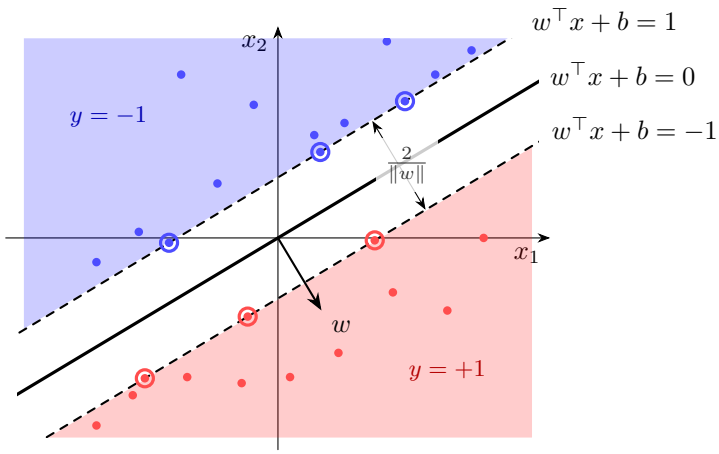


Figure 1.3: Support Vector Machine.

This yields the primal form of the SVM optimization problem:

$$\operatorname*{argmax}_{w,b} \ \frac{1}{\|w\|}, \quad \text{s.t. } y_i(w^\top x_i + b) \geq 1 \quad \forall i \tag{1.21}$$

which is equivalent to

$$\operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \ \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2, \quad \text{s.t. } y_i(w^\top x_i + b) \geq 1 \quad \forall i \tag{1.22}$$

In other words, the goal is to separate the dataset correctly while ensuring a sufficient margin, and simultaneously minimizing the norm of w. This principle is known as **Structural Risk Minimization** (SRM).

Remark

Unlike logistic regression, datapoints far from separating hyperplane do not contribute loss. That is, only small subset of dataset is active as a constraint.

Proposition 1.1

SVM is a convex quadratic programming problem, which can be solved in polynomial time with standard packages. ♡

Problem 1.1

1. What if the dataset is not linearly separable?
2. What if γ too small because of outliers?

1.5 Dual Form Of SVM

1.5.1 Preliminaries from Convex Analysis*

⊛ *This subsection is included out of personal interest and is not part of the course material. Readers who wish to focus solely on the course content may safely skip to the next subsection.*

Given a constrained optimization problem

$$\begin{aligned} \underset{x\in\mathbb{R}^n}{\text{argmin}} \quad & f(x) \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & g_i(x) \le 0, \quad i = 1, \dots, m, \\ & h_j(x) = 0, \quad j = 1, \dots, p, \end{aligned} \tag{1.23}$$

we define the *Lagrangian function* as

$$\mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu) = f(x) + \sum_{i=1}^{m} \lambda_i g_i(x) + \sum_{j=1}^{p} \nu_j h_j(x), \tag{1.24}$$

where $\lambda_i \ge 0$ are the Lagrange multipliers associated with inequality constraints, and $\nu_j \in \mathbb{R}$ correspond to equality constraints.

Definition 1.2 (Lagrangian Dual Function)

The dual function *of a lagrangian function is defined by taking the infimum over the primal variable:*

$$\theta(\lambda, \nu) = \inf_x \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu). \tag{1.25}$$

♣

The function $\theta(\lambda, \nu)$ provides a lower bound on the optimal value of the primal problem, because for any feasible x and $\lambda \ge 0$,

$$\theta(\lambda, \nu) \le f(x). \tag{1.26}$$

Definition 1.3 (Lagrangian Dual Problem)

The dual problem *seeks the tightest possible lower bound on the primal optimum by maximizing $\theta(\lambda, \nu)$:*

$$\begin{aligned} \underset{\lambda,\nu}{\text{argmax}} \quad & \theta(\lambda, \nu) \\ s.t. \quad & \lambda_i \ge 0, \quad i = 1, \dots, m. \end{aligned} \tag{1.27}$$

Equivalently,

$$\underset{\lambda \geq 0, \nu}{\operatorname{argmax}} \inf_{x} \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu). \tag{1.28}$$

♣

This formulation swaps the order of minimization and maximization, producing a problem in terms of the dual variables (λ, ν) instead of x. The resulting problem is always a *concave maximization*, even if the primal is nonconvex.

Theorem 1.5 (Weak Duality)

For any feasible x and any $\lambda \geq 0$, $\nu \in \mathbb{R}^p$, we have

$$\theta(\lambda, \nu) \leq f(x). \tag{1.29}$$

Consequently, if p^* and d^* denote the optimal values of the primal and dual problems respectively, then

$$d^* \leq p^*. \tag{1.30}$$

♡

Proposition 1.2 (Slater's Condition)

Consider the convex optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} \underset{x \in \mathbb{R}^n}{\operatorname{argmin}} \quad & f(x) \\ s.t. \quad & g_i(x) \leq 0, \quad i = 1, \ldots, m, \\ & h_j(x) = 0, \quad j = 1, \ldots, p, \end{aligned} \tag{1.31}$$

where f and all g_i are convex functions, and each h_j is affine.
If there exists a point $\bar{x}$ (called a strictly feasible point*) such that*

$$g_i(\bar{x}) < 0, \quad i = 1, \ldots, m, \qquad h_j(\bar{x}) = 0, \quad j = 1, \ldots, p, \tag{1.32}$$

*then the problem satisfies **Slater's condition**.*

♡

Slater's condition ensures that the feasible region of a convex optimization problem is not degenerate. It requires that there exists at least one point that *strictly* satisfies all inequality constraints (that is, $x \in \operatorname{Int}(C)$).

Geometrically, this means the feasible set has a *non-empty interior*. If such a point $\bar{x}$ exists, the constraint surfaces do not touch or overlap in a pathological way, and the optimizer has enough space to operate smoothly. Under this mild regularity assumption, the duality gap between the primal and dual problems vanishes, leading to **strong duality**.

Theorem 1.6 (Strong Duality)

If the primal problem is convex and satisfies the Slater condition *(i.e., there exists a strictly feasible point x such that $g_i(x) < 0$ and $h_j(x) = 0$), then*

$$d^* = p^*. \tag{1.33}$$

That is, the dual problem attains the same optimal value as the primal problem.

♡

Proof

Consider the convex optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} \underset{x \in \mathbb{R}^n}{\operatorname{argmin}} \quad & f(x) \\ s.t. \quad & Ax \leq b, \\ & Cx = d, \end{aligned} \tag{1.34}$$

where $f : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R} \cup \{+\infty\}$ is a closed and convex function, and the constraints are linear.

The Lagrangian is defined as

$$\mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu) = f(x) + \lambda^\top (Ax - b) + \nu^\top (Cx - d), \qquad \lambda \geq 0. \tag{1.35}$$

The dual function is given by

$$g(\lambda, \nu) = \inf_x \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu), \tag{1.36}$$

and the dual problem is

$$\operatorname*{argmax}_{\lambda \geq 0, \nu} g(\lambda, \nu). \tag{1.37}$$

Weak duality always holds:

$$g(\lambda, \nu) \leq f(x), \qquad \forall x \text{ feasible}, \ \lambda \geq 0, \nu. \tag{1.38}$$

Hence, $d^* \leq p^*$.

Now, suppose there exists a strictly feasible point $\bar{x}$ such that

$$A\bar{x} < b, \qquad C\bar{x} = d. \tag{1.39}$$

This satisfies the Slater's condition. By the strong duality theorem *in convex optimization (also derived from Fenchel–Rockafellar duality), there exists a saddle point (x^*, λ^*, ν^*) such that*

$$\mathcal{L}(x^*, \lambda, \nu) \leq \mathcal{L}(x^*, \lambda^*, \nu^*) \leq \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda^*, \nu^*), \qquad \forall x, \lambda \geq 0, \nu. \tag{1.40}$$

From this saddle-point condition, the minimax equality follows:

$$\operatorname*{argmin}_x \operatorname*{argmax}_{\lambda \geq 0, \nu} \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu) = \operatorname*{argmax}_{\lambda \geq 0, \nu} \operatorname*{argmin}_x \mathcal{L}(x, \lambda, \nu), \tag{1.41}$$

which implies

$$p^* = d^*. \tag{1.42}$$

Hence, strong duality holds. ■

Remark

Strong duality implies that solving the dual problem is equivalent to solving the primal one, often with additional computational and theoretical advantages, as in the case of Support Vector Machines (SVMs).

Lemma 1.1 (Gordan's Lemma)

Define the function

$$f(x) = \ln \sum_{i=1}^{m} e^{\langle a_i, x \rangle}, \tag{1.43}$$

where $\{a_i\}_{i=1}^m$ are vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$. The following statements are equivalent:

(a) $f(x)$ is bounded from below;

(b) there exists $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $\lambda \geq 0$, $\lambda \neq 0$, such that

$$\sum_{i=1}^{m} \lambda_i a_i = 0; \tag{1.44}$$

(c) there exists no x satisfying

$$\langle a_i, x \rangle < 0, \quad i = 1, \ldots, m. \tag{1.45}$$

♡

Moreover, the result can be generalized to a broader class of problems that also involve equality constraints.

Theorem 1.7 (Motzkin's transposition theorem)

Let $\{a_i\}_{i=1}^{l}$, $\{b_j\}_{j=1}^{m}$, and $\{c_k\}_{k=1}^{p}$ be vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$, and let $\{\alpha_i\}_{i=1}^{l}$, $\{\beta_j\}_{j=1}^{m}$, and $\{\gamma_k\}_{k=1}^{p}$ be scalars. Then the linear system

$$\begin{aligned} \langle a_i, x\rangle &< \alpha_i, \quad i = 1, \dots, l, \\ \langle b_j, x\rangle &\le \beta_j, \quad j = 1, \dots, m, \\ \langle c_k, x\rangle &= \gamma_k, \quad k = 1, \dots, p, \end{aligned} \tag{3.7}$$

is inconsistent if and only if there exist vectors (multipliers)

$$\lambda_0 \in \mathbb{R}, \quad \lambda \in \mathbb{R}^l, \quad \mu \in \mathbb{R}^m, \quad \delta \in \mathbb{R}^p, \tag{1.46}$$

satisfying

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=1}^{l} \lambda_i a_i + \sum_{j=1}^{m} \mu_j b_j + \sum_{k=1}^{p} \delta_k c_k &= 0, \\ \sum_{i=1}^{l} \lambda_i \alpha_i + \sum_{j=1}^{m} \mu_j \beta_j + \sum_{k=1}^{p} \delta_k \gamma_k + \lambda_0 &= 0, \\ (\lambda_0, \lambda, \mu) \ge 0, \qquad (\lambda_0, \lambda) &\ne 0. \end{aligned} \tag{3.8}$$

♡

Definition 1.4 (Hilbert Space)

*A **Hilbert space** is a complete inner product space.*

♣

1.5.2 Dual Theory in the SVM Problem

Under the intuition provided by the Lagrangian formulation, we can define the primal objective as

$$p^* = \underset{w,b}{\operatorname{argmin}} \ \underset{\alpha \ge 0}{\operatorname{argmax}} \, L(w, b, \alpha), \tag{1.47}$$

where the Lagrangian L is defined as

$$L(w, b, \alpha) = \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i (1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b)) = \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i - \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i (w^\top x_i + b). \tag{1.48}$$

We claim that:

Proposition 1.3

p^* corresponds to the solution of the primal SVM problem.

♡

To justify this, suppose the claim were false. Assume that some constraint is not satisfied, that is, there exists an index i violating the constraint such that

$$1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b) > 0. \tag{1.49}$$

Then the inner maximization problem

$$\theta_p(w, b) := \underset{\alpha \ge 0}{\operatorname{argmax}} \, L(w, b, \alpha) \tag{1.50}$$

can be driven to infinity, since the corresponding Lagrange multiplier $\alpha_i > 0$ can be increased arbitrarily to make $L(w, b, \alpha)$ unbounded above. Consequently,

$$\underset{w,b}{\operatorname{argmin}} \ \theta_p(w, b) = \underset{w,b}{\operatorname{argmin}} \ \infty \tag{1.51}$$

has no valid solution. Therefore, the initial assumption must be false, and the optimal dual variables α^* enforce all constraints to hold with equality or non-violation. Hence, the dual solution indeed corresponds to the optimal solution of

the primal problem.

Consider a convex region defined by the constraint set C. We claim that for all $x_i \in \mathrm{Int}(C)$, that is, points located strictly inside the feasible region where all constraints are satisfied, the corresponding α_i is always set to 0. For all $x_i \in \partial C = \bar{C} - \mathrm{Int}(C)$, where the constraints become active, α_i may take positive values.

As a conclusion, regardless of which region the data points fall into, the following condition holds at the optimal solution due to the complementary slackness property in the KKT conditions:

$$\sum_{i \in [n]} \alpha_i \big(1 - y_i (w^\top x_i + b)\big) = 0. \tag{1.52}$$

This does not represent an algebraic identity but a structural condition satisfied at optimality. It implies that only the points lying exactly on the margin (the support vectors) contribute to the decision boundary, while all others have $\alpha_i = 0$. Therefore, at the optimum, the objective effectively reduces to minimizing $\|w\|^2$.

Define the dual problem of p^* as follows:

$$d^* = \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} \ \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} L(w, b, \alpha), \tag{1.53}$$

where p^* is a min–max problem, while the dual problem is formulated as a max–min problem.

Theorem 1.8 (Weak Duality)

$$d^* \leq p^*. \tag{1.54}$$

Proof

By the definition of the argmin *(or equivalently, the infimum), we have*

$$d^* = \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} \ \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} L(w, b, \alpha) \ \leq \ \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} \ L(w, b, \alpha) \tag{1.55}$$

for every (w, b).

We may then choose the best (w, b) *that minimizes the right-hand side, i.e.,*

$$d^* \leq \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \ \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} L(w, b, \alpha) = p^*. \tag{1.56}$$

■

Weak duality always holds because no additional assumptions or constraints have been introduced in the argument above.

Here is another proof of the weak duality theorem:

Proof

Assume that (w_p, b_p) *is the optimal solution to the primal problem, and that* α_d *is the optimal solution to the dual problem. Then we have*

$$\begin{aligned} p^* &= \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \ \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} L(w, b, \alpha) = \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} \ L(w_p, b_p, \alpha) \\ &\geq L(w_p, b_p, \alpha_d) \geq \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \ L(w, b, \alpha_d) \\ &= \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha \geq 0} \ \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \ L(w, b, \alpha) = d^*. \end{aligned}$$

■

Remark

We study the dual problem because, in many cases, it is analytically or computationally easier to solve than the original primal problem.

Weak duality only constrains the lower bound of the original problem. Is there a better situation for d^* if we include more conditions? The answer is yes. Click here for more information.

We claim that, for convex objectives, if all the constraints are linear functions, then the **Strong Duality** holds, where

$$d^* = p^*. \tag{1.57}$$

Remark

For completeness, I provide a brief proof in the previous subsection.

In the strong duality case, the inequalities in the second proof of the weak duality theorem become equalities. That is, the intermediate solutions (w, b) in the dual problem are also optimal for the primal problem. Equivalently, the solutions of the dual and primal problems are **consistent** under strong duality.

Now, lets explicitly solve the dual problem under strong duality.

Solution

$$\operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha\geq 0} \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} L(w,b,\alpha) = \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha\geq 0} \operatorname*{argmin}_{w,b} \left(\frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i(1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b))\right) \tag{1.58}$$

To find the inner minimization over w, b, we apply the KKT stationarity conditions:

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial w} = w - \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i x_i = 0 \Rightarrow \quad w = \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i x_i, \tag{1.59}$$

$$\frac{\partial L}{\partial b} = -\sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i = 0 \Rightarrow \quad \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i = 0. \tag{1.60}$$

Substitute back into $L(w, b, \alpha)$. Plugging $w = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i x_i$ into L, we obtain:

$$L(w,b,\alpha) = \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i(1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b)) \tag{1.61}$$

$$= \frac{1}{2}\left\|\sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i x_i\right\|^2 + \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i - \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i \left(\sum_{j\in[n]} \alpha_j y_j x_j^\top x_i + b\right). \tag{1.62}$$

which follows the constraints:

$$\alpha \geq 0, \quad \sum_i \alpha_i y_i = 0 \tag{1.63}$$

Simplify L using $\sum_i \alpha_i y_i = 0$, we have

$$L(w,b,\alpha) = \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i - \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i\in[n]}\sum_{j\in[n]} \alpha_i\alpha_j y_i y_j x_i^\top x_j. \tag{1.64}$$

Thus, the SVM dual problem becomes:

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} \operatorname*{argmax}_{\alpha\geq 0} \quad & W(\alpha) = \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i - \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i,j\in[n]} \alpha_i\alpha_j y_i y_j x_i^\top x_j, \\ s.t. \quad & \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i y_i = 0. \end{aligned}} \tag{1.65}$$

Let α^* be the optimization solution of the uppon problem. Under strong duality, the optimal α^* gives rise to the optimal

w^* and b^* through:

$$w^* = \sum_{i\in[n]} \alpha_i^* y_i x_i, \qquad b^* = y_i - w^{*\top} x_i \quad \textit{for any support vector } \alpha_i^* > 0. \tag{1.66}$$

We can confirm whether (x_i, y_i) is support vector by checking whether α_i^* is positive (o.w. is zero). Thus:

$$w^* = \sum_{i\in\text{S.V.}s} \alpha_i^* y_i x_i, \qquad b^* = y_i - w^{*\top} x_i \quad \textit{for any support vector } \alpha_i^* > 0. \tag{1.67}$$

Note

At this point, the reasoning effectively reproduces Gordan's Lemma within the derivation process. I provided a brief discussion in the previous subsection.

Thus, an SVM model can be fully reconstructed from its support vectors and their corresponding coefficients α_i^*. For any test point x, the prediction depends solely on the support vectors and their weights:

$$f(x) = w^{*\top} x + b^* = \sum_{i\in\text{S.V.}} \alpha_i^* y_i \, (x_i^\top x) + b^* > 0. \tag{1.68}$$

The red term in the equation above measures the *similarity* between the test point x and each support vector x_i.

To capture non-linear relationships, we can replace this inner product with a more general **kernel function** $K(x_i, x)$, thereby mapping the data into a higher-dimensional feature space while preserving computational efficiency. We will discuss kernel tricks in the next section.

We now introduce the practical algorithm commonly used in training SVMs: the **Sequential Minimal Optimization** (SMO) method. The main idea is to iteratively update a small subset of dual variables α_i while keeping all others fixed.

However, because of the equality constraint

$$\sum_{i=1}^{n} \alpha_i y_i = 0, \tag{1.69}$$

if we fix $(n-1)$ of the α_j, the remaining one α_i is automatically determined, leaving no degree of freedom. To overcome this, SMO randomly selects a pair (α_i, α_j) and optimizes them jointly while keeping all other α_k (for $k \neq i, j$) fixed. Under this setup, the equality constraint becomes

$$\alpha_i y_i + \alpha_j y_j = -\sum_{k\neq i,j} \alpha_k y_k = \text{constant}. \tag{1.70}$$

Hence, α_j can be expressed as a linear function of α_i, and the original optimization problem reduces to a one-dimensional quadratic programming problem in α_i, which is convex (positive semidefinite).

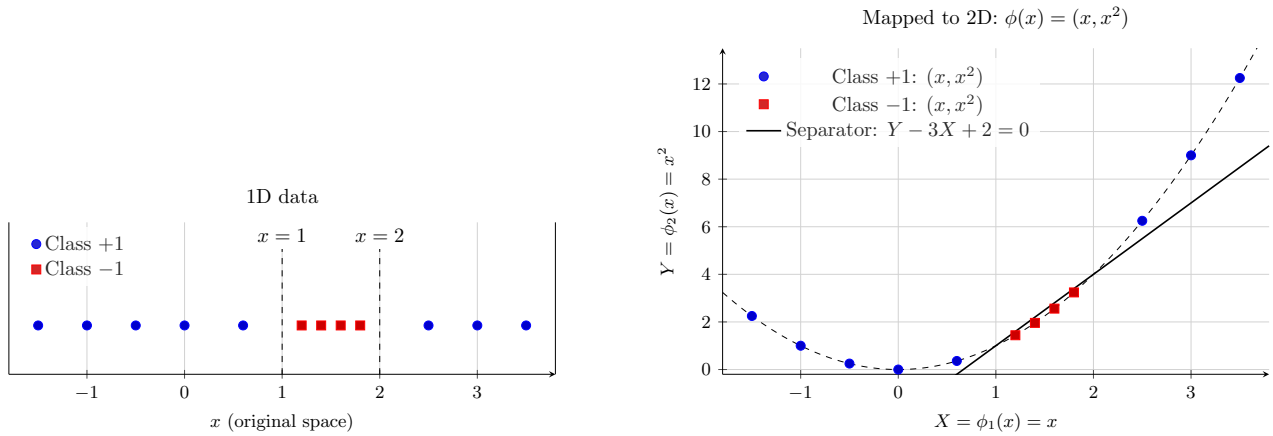
This reduction admits a **closed-form solution**, allowing efficient updates of the chosen pair (α_i, α_j).

By repeating this process iteratively over different pairs, the algorithm converges to the optimal solution of the dual problem.

1.6 Kernel

In the previous section, we only considered linearly separable datasets, which is not always satisfied in general cases.

For example, consider a one-dimensional separation problem that cannot be separated by a single point (a one-dimensional plane); we can introduce an extra dimension to transform the dataset into a linearly separable one.



That is, we want to find a function φ that maps $\mathbb{R}^d \mapsto \mathbb{R}^{d'}$ to help the separation machine complete its work. For instance, for a two-dimensional input (x_1, x_2), we can define the mapping

$$\varphi(x) := (1, x_1, x_2, x_1^2, x_2^2, x_1 x_2) \in \mathbb{R}^6, \tag{1.71}$$

which makes several implicit features in $\mathbb{R}^2$ explicit.

We can then calculate the similarity between x_1 and x_2 through their transformed features $\varphi(x)$ in (1.68):

$$f(x) = w^{*\top} x + b^* = \sum_{i \in \text{S.V.}} \alpha_i^* y_i (\varphi(x_i)^\top \varphi(x)) + b^* > 0. \tag{1.72}$$

Correspondingly, for (1.64), the dual objective becomes

$$L = \sum_{i \in [n]} \alpha_i - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j \in [n]} \alpha_i \alpha_j y_i y_j \langle \varphi(x_i), \varphi(x_j) \rangle. \tag{1.73}$$

Calculating the inner product in the high-dimensional feature space may be computationally expensive, as it often requires complex and high-order operations. Therefore, we define a **kernel function** that allows us to compute the inner product in the high-dimensional space indirectly, using only the original input vectors:

$$K(x_i, x_j) := \langle \varphi(x_i), \varphi(x_j) \rangle. \tag{1.74}$$

Definition 1.5 (Kernel Function)

*A function $K : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}$ is called a **kernel function** if there exists a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ and a mapping*

$$\phi : \mathcal{X} \to \mathcal{H} \tag{1.75}$$

such that for all $x, x' \in \mathcal{X}$,

$$K(x, x') = \langle \phi(x), \phi(x') \rangle_{\mathcal{H}}. \tag{1.76}$$

♣

In the previous example, the kernel corresponding to $\varphi(x)$ can be written as

$$K(x, z) = (x^\top z + 1)^2. \tag{1.77}$$

We can easily verify this claim:

$$\begin{aligned} K(x, z) &= (x_1 z_1 + x_2 z_2 + 1)^2 \\ &= \langle (1, \sqrt{2}x_1, \sqrt{2}x_2, x_1^2, x_2^2, \sqrt{2}x_1 x_2), (1, \sqrt{2}z_1, \sqrt{2}z_2, z_1^2, z_2^2, \sqrt{2}z_1 z_2) \rangle. \end{aligned}$$

Thus, we have effectively reduced the computational complexity from $O(d')$ to $O(d)$, thereby saving computational resources.

The dual formulation in (1.73) can then be simplified using the kernel function:

$$L = \sum_{i \in [n]} \alpha_i - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j \in [n]} \alpha_i \alpha_j y_i y_j K(x_i, x_j) \tag{1.78}$$

We now consider a new question: what kind of function K can be regarded as a valid kernel? Mercer's Theorem provides the precise answer to this problem.

Theorem 1.9 (Mercer's Theorem (Finite case))

A symmetric function $K(x, x')$ is a valid kernel if and only if, for any finite set $\{x_1, \ldots, x_n\} \subset \mathcal{X}$, the Gram matrix

$$K_{ij} = K(x_i, x_j) \tag{1.79}$$

is positive semidefinite, i.e.

$$\forall c \in \mathbb{R}^n, \quad c^\top K c \geq 0. \tag{1.80}$$

Proof

In the finite-dimensional case.Let $\{x_1, \ldots, x_n\} \subset \mathcal{X}$ be any finite subset, and define the Gram matrix $K \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ by

$$K_{ij} = K(x_i, x_j), \qquad i, j = 1, \ldots, n. \tag{1.81}$$

Since K is symmetric, we have $K = K^\top$.

By the spectral theorem for real symmetric matrices, there exists an orthonormal basis of eigenvectors $\{v_1, \ldots, v_n\}$ and corresponding real eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$ such that

$$K = V \Lambda V^\top, \tag{1.82}$$

where $V = [v_1, \ldots, v_n]$ is orthogonal and $\Lambda = \mathrm{diag}(\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n)$.

The kernel K being positive semidefinite implies that for all $c \in \mathbb{R}^n$,

$$c^\top K c = \sum_{i,j} c_i K(x_i, x_j) c_j \geq 0, \tag{1.83}$$

which in turn implies $\lambda_i \geq 0$ for all i.

Now, define feature functions

$$\phi_i(x_j) = \sqrt{\lambda_i}\, v_i(j), \tag{1.84}$$

i.e. the j-th component of v_i scaled by $\sqrt{\lambda_i}$. Then for any $x_p, x_q \in \{x_1, \ldots, x_n\}$,

$$K(x_p, x_q) = K_{pq} = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \lambda_i v_i(p) v_i(q) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \phi_i(x_p)\, \phi_i(x_q). \tag{1.85}$$

Hence, in the finite-dimensional case, K can be written as an inner product

$$K(x_p, x_q) = \langle \phi(x_p), \phi(x_q) \rangle, \qquad \phi(x) = (\phi_1(x), \ldots, \phi_n(x))^\top. \tag{1.86}$$

This directly establishes the Mercer expansion in the finite case, and the general (infinite-dimensional) theorem follows by taking the limit as $n \to \infty$. ■

Theorem 1.10 (Mercer's Theorem)

Let $\mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ be a compact set, and let $K : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}$ be a continuous, symmetric function.
*Then K is a **kernel** if and only if there exists an orthonormal basis $\{\phi_i\}_{i=1}^{\infty}$ of $L^2(\mathcal{X})$ and a sequence of non-negative eigenvalues $\{\lambda_i\}_{i=1}^{\infty}$, $\lambda_i \geq 0$, such that for all $x, x' \in \mathcal{X}$,*

$$K(x, x') = \sum_{i=1}^{\infty} \lambda_i\, \phi_i(x)\, \phi_i(x'), \tag{1.87}$$

where the series converges absolutely and uniformly on $\mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{X}$. That is, K is positive semi-definite.

Equivalently, for any square-integrable function $f \in L^2(\mathcal{X})$,

$$\iint_{\mathcal{X}\times\mathcal{X}} f(x)K(x,x')f(x')\,dx\,dx' = \sum_{i=1}^{\infty} \lambda_i \left(\int_{\mathcal{X}} f(x)\phi_i(x)\,dx \right)^2 \geq 0. \tag{1.88}$$

♡

Here are some commonly used kernels:

1. **Linear kernel**: simply applies the inner product in the original space,

$$K(x,z) = x^\top z; \tag{1.89}$$

2. **Polynomial kernel**: maps $\mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^{\binom{n+p}{p}}$,

$$K(x,z) = (x^\top z + 1)^p; \tag{1.90}$$

3. **Gaussian / RBF kernel (Radial Basis Function)**:

$$K(x,z) = \exp\left(-\frac{\|x-z\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right). \tag{1.91}$$

Remark

The RBF kernel can be intuitively understood as measuring the similarity between two vectors based on their Euclidean distance.

The RBF kernel makes any dataset linearly separable, as it effectively maps x and z into an **infinite-dimensional** Hilbert space before taking their inner product, thus providing a powerful tool for nonlinear classification.

This property follows directly from the Taylor expansion of the exponential function, noting that the polynomial basis is complete.

Remark

$$\textit{Taylor Expansion:} \quad f(x) = f(0) + f'(0)\,x + \frac{1}{2!}f''(0)\,x^2 + \frac{1}{3!}f^{(3)}(0)\,x^3 + \cdots \tag{1.92}$$

$$k(x,z) = \exp\left(-\frac{\|x\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\exp\left(-\frac{\|z\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\exp\left(\frac{x^\top z}{\sigma^2}\right) \tag{1.93}$$

$$= \exp\left(-\frac{\|x\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\exp\left(-\frac{\|z\|^2}{2\sigma^2}\right)\left[1 + \frac{x^\top z}{\sigma^2} + \frac{1}{2!}\left(\frac{x^\top z}{\sigma^2}\right)^2 + \frac{1}{3!}\left(\frac{x^\top z}{\sigma^2}\right)^3 + \cdots\right] \tag{1.94}$$

The only hyperparameter introduced here is σ^2, which determines the rate at which higher-order polynomial terms decay. A larger σ^2 implies a faster decay of these terms. Thus, σ^2 effectively controls the dimensionality of the feature space involved in the inner product.

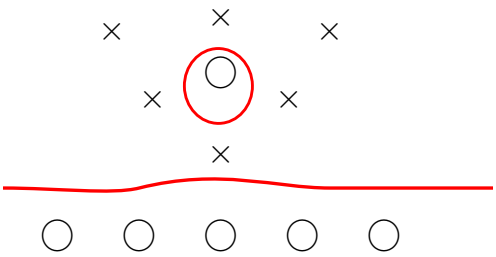
Proposition 1.4

The RBF kernel enables nonlinear classification.

♡

The above proposition follows from the behavior of the RBF kernel as $\sigma^2 \to 0^+$. In this limit, only the data point x_i closest to x contributes significantly to the kernel value, since its exponential decay is the slowest. In other words, the RBF kernel behaves almost like a **1-NN (nearest neighbor)** classifier in this regime.

To demonstrate the extraordinary capability of the RBF kernel, we note that it can represent **multiply connected**, or even **disconnected**, decision regions:



However, this expressive power also comes with a significant risk of **overfitting**.

We have now solved the non-linearly separable problem mentioned at the end of the last section, and we arrive at the next challenge: the presence of outliers.

To address this issue, we introduce the concept of **slack variables**. The idea is intuitive yet powerful — instead of forcing every data point to lie strictly on the correct side of the margin, we allow some samples to *violate* the margin constraint slightly, while penalizing these violations in the objective function.

Formally, we define non-negative variables

$$\xi_i \geq 0, \quad i = 1, \ldots, n, \tag{1.95}$$

called *slack variables*, representing the amount by which each sample fails to satisfy the margin condition. The optimization problem then becomes

$$\begin{aligned} \underset{w,b,\xi}{\text{argmin}} \quad & \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + C\sum_{i=1}^{n}\xi_i, \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & y_i(w^\top x_i + b) \geq 1 - \xi_i, \quad i = 1, \ldots, n, \\ & \xi_i \geq 0, \quad i = 1, \ldots, n. \end{aligned} \tag{1.96}$$

where $C > 0$ is a hyperparameter controlling the trade-off between maximizing the margin and minimizing classification errors.

In this way, the model, known as the **Soft-Margin SVM**, allows small violations of the margin to achieve a better balance between robustness and generalization. This is the most commonly used form of SVM in practice.

We claim that the constraints on the slack variables are equivalent to the following formulation:

$$\xi_i \geq \max(0,\ 1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b)). \tag{1.97}$$

In the minimization problem

$$\arg\min_{w,b,\xi} \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + C\sum_i \xi_i, \tag{1.98}$$

it is crucial to observe that each ξ_i will always take the minimal feasible value,either 0 or $1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b)$. Otherwise, if ξ_i were larger than necessary, the objective $\sum_i \xi_i$ could be further reduced by decreasing ξ_i.

Thus, the optimization problem can be reformulated as an unconstrained objective:

$$\underset{w,b}{\text{argmin}} \ \frac{1}{2}\|w\|^2 + C\sum_{i=1}^{n}\max(0,\ 1 - y_i(w^\top x_i + b)). \tag{1.99}$$

This formulation introduces the **Hinge loss**.

Definition 1.6 (Hinge loss)

The hinge loss function $L(z)$ is defined as:

$$L(z) = \max(0,\ 1 - z). \tag{1.100}$$

♣

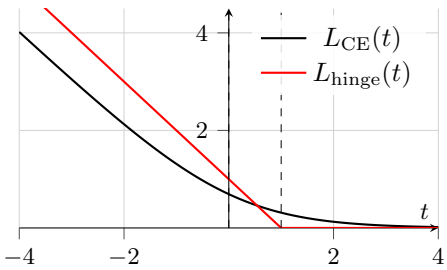


Figure 1.4: Hinge loss and CE loss.

Intuitively, the hinge loss $L_{\mathrm{hinge}}(t)$ remains zero when $t \geq 1$. This property directly enforces a margin: samples that already lie beyond the decision boundary (i.e., sufficiently far from the separating hyperplane) incur no loss, while those within or on the wrong side of the margin contribute a positive penalty. In this sense, the hinge loss explicitly encourages a wider margin between classes.

For comparison, consider the cross-entropy loss:

$$-\log(\sigma(z)) = \log(1 + e^{-z}), \tag{1.101}$$

where $\sigma(z)$ denotes the sigmoid function.

Remark

In class, we used $\log_2$ *instead of the natural logarithm, leading to an approximation when* $x \to -\infty$*:*

$$\log(1 + e^{-z}) \sim \frac{-z}{\log_2 e}, \tag{1.102}$$

which results in a slightly different scaling in the plotted curve.

Both the cross-entropy loss and the hinge loss serve as *substitute losses* for the zero-one loss:

$$L_{\text{zero-one}}(z) = \begin{cases} 1, & z < 0, \\ 0, & z \geq 0. \end{cases} \tag{1.103}$$

The zero-one loss is non-differentiable and provides no gradient information, so gradient-based optimization methods cannot be directly applied in this case.